WELCOME ADDRESS

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Nineteen years ago, in the presence of Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee, we had kicked off a two-day conclave at which the theme was 'Building an Indian Century'. We knew the idea was aspirational but worth testing. Surprisingly, the galaxy of speakers not only endorsed the idea but also suggested pathways to building an Indian century. That included Prime Minister Vajpayee, Leader of the Opposition Sonia Gandhi, Mukesh Ambani, Raghuram Rajan and Colin Powell—among others.

The following year, the theme was 'India: Global Giant or Pygmy'. The gala night speaker was President Bill Clinton. He exhorted us by saying, and I quote, "The world cannot afford for India to be a pygmy. You have to be a giant and the right kind of giant." With over a fifth of the 21st century gone, The Giant has Arrived.

It is India's Moment.

From economy to geopolitics to entertainment to sports. India's graph is on the rise. Let's look at some significant developments to see how India has shaped up in this century so far.

In 2000, India's economy was less than 5 per cent of the US economy in dollar terms. Today, it is 14 per cent. Last year, India became the fifth-largest economy in the world. We are also the fastest-growing large economy in the world. We have recently become the most populous country on the planet with 1.4 billion people, out of which 1 billion are below the age of 35, while many other countries have ageing populations. This means we are an aspirational nation, and that signifies we are an amazing market for anybody.

The development which is changing India the most is our phenomenal pace of digitisation. It is transforming people's lives at the top and bottom of the pyramid. We have the world's highest mobile data consumption and the second largest internet users. Three people join the net in India every second, and two are from villages.

This is India's moment.

Perhaps the most significant proof of India's socio-economic change is the unstoppable rise of the start-up ecosystem. Where their parents and grandparents saw risk, today's youth see reward. This mindset change has resulted in India having the third-largest number of unicorns and start-ups in the world. In 2021, India added a unicorn every 29 days, and in 2022, an incredible one every nine days. There is no better proof than this that Indian entrepreneurship is alive and kicking.

This, too, is India's moment.

Now that climate change is on everyone's mind, India, with 350 days of sunshine over a vast land mass and the prospect of green hydrogen, will probably be a world leader in renewable energy in the years to come.

And, of course, we won two Oscars last week. Growing evidence of India's rise as a soft power. India has literally got the world dancing to our tune, 'Naatu Naatu.'

Apart from India's efforts, a confluence of external circumstances has put the country in a sweet spot. 'The India Moment', so to speak, is what this conclave is all about.

First came Covid in 2019, which made the world go